profusion of spam threatened to make the use of email impossible. Powerful algorithms were developed to address the problem. By 2015, Google claimed its Gmail algorithm had a 99.9 per cent success rate in blocking genuine spam, while only 1 per cent of legitimate emails were erroneously labelled as such.[20]

We also shouldn't discount the huge social benefits that YouTube, Facebook and other social media platforms have brought. To be clear, most YouTube videos and Facebook posts have *not* been fake news and genocidal incitements. Social media has been more than helpful in connecting people, giving voice to previously disenfranchised groups and organising valuable new movements and communities.[21] It has also encouraged an unprecedented wave of human creativity. In the days when television was the dominant medium, viewers were often denigrated as couch potatoes: passive consumers of content that a few gifted artists produced. Facebook, YouTube and other social media platforms inspired the couch potatoes to get up and start creating. Most of the content on social media – at least until the rise of powerful generative AI – has been produced by the users themselves, and their cats and dogs, rather than by a limited professional class.

I, too, routinely use YouTube and Facebook to connect with people, and I am grateful to social media for connecting me with my husband, whom I met on one of the first LGBTQ social media platforms back in 2002. Social media has done wonders for dispersed minorities like LGBTQ people. Few gay boys are born to a gay family in a gay neighbourhood, and in the days before the internet simply finding one another posed a big challenge, unless you moved to one of the handful of tolerant metropolises that had a gay subculture. Growing up in a small homophobic town in Israel in the 1980s and early 1990s, I didn't know a single openly gay man. Social media in the late 1990s and early 2000s provided an unprecedented and almost magical way for members of the dispersed LGBTQ community to find one another and connect.

And yet I have devoted so much attention to the social media 'user engagement' debacle because it exemplifies a much bigger problem afflicting computers – the alignment problem. When computers are given a specific goal, such as to increase YouTube traffic to one billion hours a day, they use all their power and ingenuity to achieve this goal. Since they operate very differently from humans, they are likely to use methods their